

How To Answer Toughest Competency Interview Questions and Answers

Just as the name sounds, competency-based interview questions are questions that check your competencies in the position that you are applying for. Competencies like skills, abilities, behaviours, and knowledge of the position that you are applying for are things that will be checked for when asked a competency based question

1. Tell me about a time you led or worked in a team

This interview question is a situational question. This kind of question tends to see how you would show your competency in a particular situation. Your response to the question will help the interviewer understand how you would react in a particular situation.

The STAR method is a great approach to attempting this question

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When you are answering these questions, you should focus on the following:

Give an example of where you demonstrated working in a team

Make the interviewer understand how you have worked in a team

You should avoid the following:

Avoid sounding like a lazy person

Avoid sounding unprofessional

Sample Answers

“In my previous job as a sales executive, we were divided into teams to see how we can improve sales on the new product. My team members and I developed a plan to have each member handle a specific area so that we specialize and deliver at the right time.

At the end of the day, we were able to increase sales with up 10% from what we used to have in the previous year”.

2. Describe a situation where you solved a problem

Employers usually ask this question because they believe that problems solvers have an amazing attitude that makes them face up with challenges and an open mind that makes them learn easily.

Since challenges are inevitable when performing any task or in any work environment, employers tend to ask this question to have an idea about how you would react when you are been faced with some of the challenges.

Pay attention to the following details when you are answering the question:

Makes sure you identify a real problem that you have solved sometimes in the past

Carefully walk the interviewer through the problem and how you were able to solve it
Use the STAR method to organize your response

Make sure that the problem that you have chosen to talk about is one that will contain the skills that the interviewer needs to evaluate that you are the right person for the job

You should also avoid the following:

Don't give an example of an unrealistic problem

Don't pick a problem that will not emphasize your skills and abilities

Avoid talking about a problem that you were not able to solve at the end

Sample Answers

"In my previous role as an account manager, we got a deal from one of our top clients, and as we were about to start the processes, our top employee resigned and there was nobody readily available with that kind of experience that can handle that kind of request"

"Even though I was handling loads of project already, I had to take up the responsibility of managing the clients account to salvage the situation because, with that deal, we will meet up to 45% of our target for the year"

"I worked extra 5 hours on work days, and all through the weekend to make sure that we deliver at the right time. When we finished with the project, we were able to deliver it in 3 days before the deadline. At the end of that project, were able to meet up with our target for the year and we kept the promise we made to our client"

3. Describe a situation where you showed leadership

Leadership is one of the competencies that employers look for when they look forward to getting a recent hire. It is easy for you to think that leadership abilities are the most sort after in management positions, but that is not always the case. Interviewers ask this question because of the following reasons:

If you are applying for a management position, then they are asking this question because they want to know if you will be able to jump in and perform the leadership role immediately.

Some other job roles like project management will require you to learn how to work together with people effectively

If you are applying for an entry-level position, then they are asking you the question because they want to know how you will thrive in a leadership position. They may want to know how fast you can grow internally

You will need to consider the following details to answer the question directly:

You have to sell yourself properly

Be ready to tell a good interview story using the STAR format

Sample Answers

“In my previous company, we experienced a serious financial breakdown, and as a result of that, the company dissolved some of the departments and laid off many workers too. So there was so much workload on the remaining people that were there and it was almost frustrating for them that they wanted to quit. I had to show them that there is a need to do whatever you do well with my performance and enthusiasm. I consciously took on more work, which led and motivated them to do more”

“In my previous company, where I worked as the team lead, I noticed that my team members were becoming unconcerned and lazy about their work, this was a serious problem for me because I had to fill in the gap which means taking up more jobs. I discovered what the problem was a new staff member that did not like what he was doing and tried to drag other team members to do the same. I spoke to the man and advised the HR unit to fix him in another role where he can perform better, they did that and I put in more effort to be diligent in my work and also show that I love what I do. The team came back to normal and we were able to achieve all our goals for the year”

4. Give an example of a time when you spearheaded a project

With the question, the interviewer wants to know your leadership ability and how you take initiative to handle a project. Interviewers ask this question to have an idea about how you can solely take charge of a project and deliver.

How to answer this question:

Give examples about times that you have managed people

Make sure that the example you give should be one that demonstrates a time that you delivered a good result on time

Talk about the resources you made use of and how you made use of those resources to achieve the result

You should also avoid:

Avoid talking about how much you hate taking leadership roles

Avoid talking about how much the project frustrated you

Sample Answers

“In my previous company where I worked as a technical lead, it is my duty to make sure that every project is successful. The first thing that I did was to look at things that may likely prevent us from achieving our goals after I must have written down and brainstormed on the goals we want to achieve.

I scheduled meetings with people that I know will contribute to the success of the project. I organized different sessions to help us work better on the project, I worked overtime and on weekends to make sure that the project is successful and on time”

If you are applying for an entry-level position;

“During my internship, I headed a small team of interns like myself to develop a user feedback system that would work on the new website that we were building. I divided the group into 4 units and shared responsibilities among team members, I shared the responsibilities into the different task that I labeled (ABCD) I handled A while other team members did their part. At the end of the day, we came together and integrated the whole system to one robust system. The project got the attention of the managing director and we were commended for it. This project opened the door to other projects”.

5. Describe a time when you made a mistake in your work

This is one question that may come out as tricky because you are made to talk about your own mistakes. Interviewers ask this kind of question to understand how you face challenges and your approach to the challenges that you face.

Interviewers also use this question to determine your weakness to know how well you will perform if you are given the job.

Consider following these steps to answers the question effectively:

The best way to tackle this question is talking about a particular mistake that you made

Briefly explain the mistake, but don't dwell on it

Talk about what you have learned in the course of the mistake

You should also be careful not to do the following:

Be careful not to mention a mistake that would be critical to your success

Avoid mentioning a mistake that is a flaw to your character

Sample Answers

"When I was new in my previous company, I accepted to take on two projects from different people simultaneously even when I knew that I may not be able to handle it. I didn't tell them to think that I could not handle the job. I could not explain to any of them that I was handling another project"

"I could not meet up with the deadline for the projects, so I told my manager and she assigned another person to work with me to hasten the project. I learned to keep my employers updated on any task and take on tasks that I can handle easily"

6. How do you minimize the risk of errors in your work

This type of interview question is usually asked to check the candidate's level of accuracy.

Most interviewers ask this question because they want to know how much you can work with minimal errors. Interviewers always ask accounting candidates this question. This is a competency-based question that checks a candidate accuracy competency.

You should take note of the following when answering this question:

Give an example of a work that you have done earlier

Give instances of your accuracy

Show the interviewer that you are capable of the work

You should avoid the following:

Avoid giving answers that are not related to the question

Sample Answer

"Working as an accountant, I know how errors can sabotage the whole accounting process. In the early years of my career, I used to double check my work to make sure that all the details are entered correctly, but later I discovered that checking the work twice is not enough so I decided to start checking the accuracy of the data even before I start entering them.

So I stopped checking my work twice and started checking it several times"

7. How do you deal with stress?

Employers know that everyone feels stressed at one point or the other while performing their task. So, when you are asked interview questions about how you deal with stress, the interviewer does not expect you say that you don't feel stressed.

The interviewer only wants to know how stress affects you and how you go about dealing with it.

When you are answering this question, you pay attention to the following:

Give an example of how you have handled stress well in the past

Talk about a stressful situation that is related to the work

Walk the interview through how you managed stress previously

You should avoid doing the following:

Avoid talking about a stressful situation that is not related to the job

Avoid talking too much about the stress rather than how you were able to manage it

Avoid giving answers like this *"I never feel stressed"*

Sample Answers

"I know that sometimes it is hard to avoid stress, but I try to face the situation, rather than being stressed. Regardless of how much work I have to do, I make sure that I tackle the situation rather than being overwhelmed by the problem. That way, I handle the situation better and don't get stressed. For example, when I dealt with an unsatisfied customer that was really angry and was ready to give a negative review about our product. Instead of feeling stressed, I concentrated on finding out what her challenge was exactly and looked for ways to help her get the problem solved addressing it to the right channel. My ability to remain calm when dealing with the unsatisfied customer reduced my stress and the stress that the customer may face"

"For me, communication is key to a stressful situation. Many times, I communicate as much as possible to make sure that I am on the same page with everyone involved in what I am working on. It reduces errors and cuts down stress to a very large extent. In my previous job, I was working on a project with another team and found out that after a while we had a different approach on the same project. I called for a stand-up meeting so that we can come to a logical conclusion and carry on with the project. At the end of the day, we agreed on one vision and the project went on successfully".

8. How do you plan to ensure you complete a number of tasks effectively?

Most times employers or interviewers ask this question so that they can understand how you are able to juggle task. This question basically assesses your ability to multi-task.

Multi-tasking is one of the abilities that employers look forward to when trying to get a new hire because most times, you may not always do the things that are in your job description. You may likely be asked to perform other task side by side your major task.

When you are answering this question, you should pay attention to the following points:

Give an example of a time that you managed multiple task

Walk the interviewer through your multi-tasking process and how you were able to meet up with deadlines

Always avoid errors like:

Telling the interviewer how much you hate multi-tasking

Avoid giving short or too general answers like; “I love multi-tasking a lot” “I always find a way to get anything done”

Sample Answers

“No matter the number of tasks I have to complete, I always calm down first and figure the best way to go about completing the task. Whenever I have multiple tasks to complete, I start by organizing the tasks from the most important to the least important task, then I would start working on the most important task. If I am experiencing any challenge working on any of the tasks, I don’t hesitate to ask a professional for assistance”

“Whenever I have multiple tasks to complete, I, first, of all, maintain a positive mindset on the whole task and avoid getting frustrated. I then come up with a plan to carry out the task and meet up with the set deadline. And if I cannot meet up with the set deadline, I would politely ask for an extension”

9. What was the biggest change you had to deal with in your previous employment? How did you handle it?

Change is one thing that is unavoidable in life, both in your personal and career life. When interviewers ask you questions about how you dealt with a change, they simply want to know how well you can handle change when the situation arises.

The interviewer would love to know how flexible you are, and how you can deal with change because it is inevitable sometimes.

You can answer this question well with the following guidelines:

Give an example of a real-life situation where you dealt with change

Talk about how the change affected your job and how you were able to deal with the situation regardless of the change

Don't forget to mention that change is a part of the work life, that all you have to do is to embrace it and work with it

You should also avoid:

Capitalizing on the negative change

Avoid criticizing the factor that led to the change

Sample Answers

"I understand that change happens and it may likely happen when one is not prepared for it. No matter how the change comes, I try to maintain a positive attitude towards it and understand the purpose of the change. This approach helps me get used to the change quickly and set my eyes on the goals that we set to achieve.

In my previous position, I was working as a content developer charged with the full responsibility of developing content for the websites. Then the company hired a new content developer without stating what my contribution would be. I walked up to my supervisor and asked her about my contribution to the team, she explained to me that I will handle the more complex content while the new hire takes care of the other ones. This gave me better clarity on my role, and I could help the new hire get used to her role too".

"I know that change can happen when you least expect it, but whenever a change happens I keep an open mind to embrace it. In my previous employment, I got used to working alone with little or no supervision at all. The director hired a manager that I was supposed to report to. Understanding her goal for a project was a bit of a struggle for me, but as time went on I came up with a plan to have a meeting with her before I start working on any project to make sure that we are on the same page. As time went on I understood her perfectly and we achieved more working together as a team"

10. How do you build relationships with other members of your team?

The relationship that you build with your team members goes a long way to determine how productive you will be at work.

Teamwork is always one top skill that employers look out for when they are trying to get a new hire.

Employers ask this question to see how well you can work in a team and to see level of relationship you have with other employees

When you are answering this question, you should focus on the following:

Use specific examples

Demonstrate your interpersonal skills even from the way that you speak with the interviewer

Emphasize with your answers that you build a good relationship with people

You should avoid the following:

Focusing on the negative or blaming another person

Avoid showing any trait that may likely play down on your interpersonal skills

Sample Answers

“I understand that building a good relationship with team members will increase productivity. When I am new to a team, I try to first understand the personalities of team members. Understanding their personality type will help you better deal with them. I also get interested in what they do and show concern about their interest and goals, then we can communicate on a more shared ground”

“I build an interpersonal relationship with my team members by building interest around what they do. In my current job, I always take a look at what someone has done and give a form of review or an opinion about how it can be better, or simply encourage good work. I was known to be the eagle’s eye of my team”